

Mountain mindfulness script
(based on Kabat-Zinn, *wherever you go, there you are* p.73)

You may use the ideas in this mindfulness script as they are, or change them as you see fit. They can be put to use in longer sessions or relatively briefly. At their center is the idea of drawing power from an inner image, which you can invoke at any time and in any place.

Sit in a comfortable way. Picture the most beautiful mountain you know or can imagine. Focus on its image and the feeling it invokes in you. Notice its overall shape. Imagine its peaks as well as its base, rooted into the earth's crust. The steep or gently sloping sides. Note how massive it is, how unmoving, how beautiful whether seen from afar or up close.

Perhaps your mountain has snow at the top and trees on the lower slopes. Perhaps it has one prominent peak, perhaps a series of peaks or a high plateau. However it appears, just sit and breathe with the image of this mountain, observing it, noting its qualities.

When you feel ready, see if you can bring the mountain into your own body so that *your body* sitting here *and the mountain* of the mind's eye *become one*. Your head becomes the lofty peak; your shoulders and arms the sides of the mountain; your buttocks and legs the solid base rooted to your cushion on the floor or to your chair. Experience in your body the sense of uplift, the elevated quality of the mountain deep in your own spine.

Invite yourself to become a breathing mountain, unwavering in your stillness, completely what you are—beyond words and thought, a centered, rooted, unmoving presence.

Now, as well you know, throughout the day as the sun travels the sky, the mountain just sits. Light and shadow and colors are changing virtually moment to moment in the mountain's stillness. As the light changes, as night follows day and day follows night, the mountain just sits, simply being itself. It remains still as the seasons flow into one another and as the weather changes moment by moment and day by day. Calmness abiding all change.

In spring, the mountain may be covered in blooming flowers; by the fall, these may lose their luster. In winter, clouds or fog could obscure it, or it may be

pelted by freezing rain. The tourists who come to visit may be disappointed if they can't see the mountain clearly because of the fog, but it's all the same to the mountain—seen or unseen, in sun or clouds, broiling or frigid, it just sits, being itself. Unmoved by the weather, by what happens on the surface, by the world of appearances.

As we sit holding this image in our mind, we can embody the same unwavering stillness and rootedness in the face of everything that changes in our own lives over seconds, hours, and years. In our lives we experience constantly the changing nature of mind and body and of the outer world. We experience periods of light and dark, vivid color and drab dullness. We experience storms of varying intensity and violence, in the outer world and in our own lives and minds. We endure periods of darkness and pain as well as savoring moments of joy and uplift.

By becoming the mountain in our mind, we can link up with its strength and stability, and adopt them for our own. We can use its energies to support our efforts to encounter each moment with mindfulness, equanimity, and clarity. It may help us to see that our thoughts and feelings, our preoccupations, our emotional storms and crises, even the things that happen to us are much like the weather on the mountain.

Invoking the mountain within us can help us gain a sense of strength and stability. For the next couple of moments, I invite you to keep meditating on your connection to the mountain, quietly, until you hear the sound of the bell.

[after one minute – sound chime]

In daily life, we can invoke this image and feeling of this inner mountain in various ways: in stillness or motion, briefly or at greater length. In our materials, we've included a recording of this mindfulness script, and I invite you to listen to it every day or two for the next couple of weeks, and explore its usefulness, especially in the face of worry, adversity, and uncertainty – the clouds and storms in the mind. Ask yourself what you are learning from your experiments with this practice. Can you see some subtle transformation occurring in your attitude toward things that change in your life? Can you carry the mountain image with you in daily life? Can you see the mountain in others, and allow them their own shape and form, each mountain uniquely itself?